

Many **writers**, such as James **Joyce**, George **Orwell**, and Kurt **Vonnegut** have **refused** to use semicolons, deeming them pointless.

GLOSSARY

Clause A grammatical unit that contains a subject and a verb. Sentences are made up of one or more clauses.

Main clause A clause that makes complete sense on its own.

Subordinate clause A clause that provides additional information but depends on the main clause for it to make sense.

REAL WORLD

Ben Jonson's *English Grammar*

English dramatist Ben Jonson (1572–1637) is widely credited as the first person to set down rules on how to use semicolons in English. His book *English Grammar*, first published in 1640, systematically examined the period, comma, semicolon, and colon. Before this, there were no accepted standards on how to use these marks.

**Before adverbs**

A semicolon precedes certain adverbs, such as *however*, *therefore*, *consequently*, and *nevertheless*, when they are used as conjunctions to connect clauses.

However is used as a conjunction here, so it is preceded by a semicolon.

June was hot; however, some cities were rainy.

June was hot; however, some Texas; and Boston, England.

Lists

When a sentence includes a list in which some or all of the items already contain commas, semicolons are used to separate the list items. This makes the sentence easier to follow.

Without the semicolons, the reader might mistake *Texas* and *England* for cities.

Some cities were rainy: London; Paris, Texas; and Boston, England.

Commas separate cities from regions.

A region is needed to clarify which *Paris* the text is referring to.

A region is needed to clarify which *Boston* the text is referring to.